Losing Her (and Searching for Myself)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50444260.

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Mature

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by ResFlower

Summary

"I am your Adora." The words burst out of her without permission, much like the lump in her throat. "I'm just...I'm older. Much older if I had to guess." Catra is at an age where it's hard to tell if she's in her mid-twenties or thirties but she's vibrant and full of life.

"Fuck, really?" She groans kicking a rock next to her. "This is really fucking annoying. The portal was supposed to short circuit distance, not time." Catra slumps over against a tree, leaning her head against it. She then eyes Adora curiously. "What's up with you and all the staring?" She smirks, one of her ears twitching. "Am I on some far-off diplomatic trip with Sparkles? I bet you hate that."

She shakes her head slowly, not sure what to even say. "I—Catra." The tears spring to her eyes now, not much she can do about it. "You're—You've been gone."

Her ears pin back and she stares at Adora, understanding marring her face. "I'm dead?"

OR

Catra dies and Adora has to live with the grief of it all. Dead Catra AU.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

"Adora, you need to eat. I'm not asking." Glimmer is demanding and gruff in a way many people haven't dared act in front of Adora since the news broke.

She ignores her friend, waving her away. "I'm fine." The last thing Adora feels is hungry these days. There's a gnawing emptiness in her gut, but it's nothing food can solve.

Glimmer all but tamps her foot down and it reminds Adora of when they were younger. "Please. You haven't been taking care of yourself. You know Catra would—"

Her nostrils flair in anger. "Don't talk about Catra to me." She knows Glimmer misses her, but it's *nothing* like how Adora feels. She has no idea.

She sighs, clearly at the end of her tether. "Please, I'm just—"

"Just *don't* then, Glimmer." Adora shakes her head. "You have your husband and your kids and your grandkids. Don't lecture me how I'm supposed to act now that my wife is *dead*."

Even saying the words aloud doesn't make them feel real. That's been the worst part of the last few weeks. She keeps expecting to be wrong—to find Catra sitting in their living room reading a book, or taking a cat nap, or cooking something in their kitchen. Decades of memories, of habits and routines halted to a grind. Her whole life is in tatters around her.

"Will you at least consider moving in with us?" She asks tiredly, one hand on her hips.

Adora shakes her head before Glimmer even finishes the sentence. "I'm not moving to Bright Moon. Or with Finn." She's—Adora knows she's a wreck. She's under no delusion of just how torn apart she is. She doesn't need to burden everyone else with that.

"You shouldn't stay alone in that house. It's not good for you."

"That's my house. I'm not living anywhere but there." Adora sighs, tired of everything. Always, so tired. "I know you mean well. But there's nothing that can fix this. I miss her so much." Her voice is thick with tears by the end of it.

Adora isn't even surprised. For a while, she was shocked she could cry this much and this often, but she has quickly found there's no end to how often she could cry over Catra. She wishes Catra was there so much. She'd give anything to have her, even for just one day.

Glimmer pulls her into a tight hug. "I know. I miss her too." She gives Adora a pitying look. "I just—you're not dead. You need to find a way to live without her."

She lets her arm fall around her friend but it doesn't really warm her. Nothing touches her when she's like this. "I don't remember what it is to live without her."

The longest stretch was during the war, and this hurt so much worse. At least when they were at odds, Adora knew that Catra was probably safe. That she'd see her again at some point and there would be a chance, however small, that she could convince Catra to join her.

Of course, it never worked out that way. After the war was over, Adora always privately pondered a thought—the hope that if anything were to happen to Catra, she could use her healing powers to bring her back, just like she did after she rescued Catra from Prime.

That didn't work this time. Castaspella thinks it's because ultimately, sick or not, Catra died of natural causes. She thinks that Adora's magic isn't meant to fix something like that. It didn't stop Adora from trying, from pumping every ounce of her magic into Catra's dead body until she passed out from exhaustion.

Finn yelled at her for that, calling her a stubborn old woman who was trying to give them a heart attack. She hadn't cared much at

the time.

Glimmer sighs, putting a hand on Adora's shoulder. "We're here. No matter what time or whatever you need."

Adora cracks a slight smile. "I know. I love you too."

"Come next week for dinner with all the kids. Mermista is going to be in town too." Mermista had lost Sea Hawk a few years prior and had never been quite the same but she's managed to cobble together a good life. Adora kind of hates her for it now, which in turn makes her guilty.

"I'll try to make it." Adora knows she won't be ready by then but she doesn't have the heart to break it to Glimmer.

Being in their house is torture as much as it is a comfort. The memories burn and make Adora’s heart ache, even as it helps her hold herself together. She's woven by it, the fabric of the time they spent together here. It wasn't all good—there were fights and arguments, days when Catra lashed out or Adora grew distant. But they always found a way forward together.

Today, it was a memory of Catra quietly padding into their makeshift office, an apology on her lips. *I don't want to wait my time fighting you, princess. We've done that enough, don't you think?*

The words echo in Adora's brain. How silly she was to give up any of the time she'd had with Catra. She sighs, getting up and going outside. The cottage she and Catra built is on the outskirts of the Whispering Woods which makes it easy for her to walk into the foliage and get lost.

She's not really lost—not physically, at least. She's painfully aware of how far she is from her home, from Bright Moon. It doesn't matter—she's lost in all the ways that matter. Adora sinks to her knees and pounds the ground with her hand.

It's not fair. Everyone who tries to comfort her tells her that she's lucky for the years they did have together—for the life lived. But Adora isn't ready to say goodbye—she's never been able to. Why did everyone think that she should be equipped for that, after a lifetime dedicated to loving Catra?

"I miss you so much." She whispers it into the ground, tears rolling down her cheeks. "I love you so much, Catra. I didn't want you to leave."

Adora is foolish, even now in her early sixties. She'd thought if she wished it hard enough Catra would be healthy again. Catra was so tired by the end of it, barely able to open her eyes when someone walked into the room. It haunted her—how many of the things she had left to say did Catra hear? Understand? Did she know in the end that Adora never strayed from her bedside? Did she know how much Adora loved her? How much Finn missed her? All of the friends who came and sat with her when she was in and out of consciousness?

It feels like gravity is heavier on her than on anyone else—like her bones want to snap into Etheria. To join Catra in the ground where she belongs. She doesn't want to go but she's so *tired*. She can't even think about anything but grief slamming into her, covering her like a heavy blanket. She can't hope to find the edge of it, suffocating underneath like a child.

"Anyone out here?" Adora thinks she's hearing something but there's no way anyone but her would dare to go this deep into the Whispering Woods.

Still, she leans up, wiping her face of her tears and trying to lock her grief back—hoping for some semblance of normalcy if she does run into a stranger. She barely gets to her feet when she feels like she's about to be knocked back onto the ground.

It's Catra. Not the sickly older version that Adora loved and lost, but a younger one that Adora has only seen in her dreams.

"Adora?" Adora's mouth runs dry as she looks at her. Catra looks beautiful and young like she's straight out of a picture from when they were younger. She's staring at Adora with her head tilted, ears twitching as her eyes narrow. "You are Adora, aren't you? You look different."

She clenches her hands tightly to her side, trying to stop the shaking. It's gotten worse since she doesn't have Catra to help with it any longer.

"What are you—are you even real?"

There are so many possible explanations. Maybe it's a hologram—it wouldn't be the first time—or a trick of the light. Maybe Adora is simply losing her damn mind. That seems like the most likely scenario. Whatever it is, it makes more sense that this actually being Catra standing before her.

She laughs, startled. "Of course, I'm real. I'm just trying to figure out where I am." Her eyes are wide as she looks at Catra.

"Where were you trying to go?" It's a surreal conversation but she feels better than she has in weeks. She's definitely lost it, but maybe that's not so bad if she gets to see Catra like this.

She eyes Adora wearily. "Somewhere that's not Etheria. So, the fact that I'm in the Whispering Woods means I've failed." Catra sighs, running a hand through her hair. It's at a mid-length as if she were growing it out from a shorter haircut. "So, I'm asking again. Where am I? Because you don't look like my Adora, the one who was sleeping next to me this morning."

"I am your Adora." The words burst out of her without permission, much like the lump in her throat. "I'm just...I'm older. Much older if I had to guess." Catra is at an age where it's hard to tell if she's in her mid-twenties or thirties but she's vibrant and full of life.

"Fuck, really?" She groans kicking a rock next to her. "This is really fucking annoying. The portal was supposed to short circuit distance, not time." Catra slumps over against a tree, leaning her

head against it. She then eyes Adora curiously. "What's up with you and all the staring?" She smirks, one of her ears twitching. "Am I on some far-off diplomatic trip with Sparkles? I bet you *hate* that."

Adora lets out a laugh that's more like a cough. Catra is right—the few intergalactic trips that Catra and Glimmer took without her made her miss Catra so bad she'd all but toss her over her shoulder the moment she landed on Etheria. Catra would laugh and tease her for it but she'd cling to Adora just as tightly, whispering about how much she missed her. Adora wishes it were that simple now.

She shakes her head slowly, not sure what to even say. "I—Catra." The tears spring to her eyes now, not much she can do about it. "You're—You've been *gone*."

Her ears pin back and she stares at Adora, understanding marring her face. "I'm dead?"

Adora nods gently, pushing the tears off her face. "A few weeks ago." She informs her.

Her face floods with understanding. "Oh, Adora. I'm so sorry." She takes a step closer but seems to stop herself, looking down at her feet. "How is Finn taking it?"

Adora cries even harder at the tender worry in Catra's voice. This Catra is already a mother and loves Finn like she does. She's the closest thing Adora will ever have to *her* Catra, and she's not even close.

"They're doing alright. It wasn't ... unexpected." She's not sure what this Catra might want to know about her death but she doesn't want to force the gory details on her either. "Finn misses you to pieces though." So do their kids, but Adora is sure Catra doesn't know about those.

She nods softly. "I'm sorry. For showing up, this has to be—I can't imagine." There's an almost haunted look in her eyes and it

somehow makes Adora feel better.

"No. No, it's fine." This is the best Adora has felt since Catra died in her arms. "Let's go to Bright Moon and see if we can fix this." Adora hasn't had something to fix that she could help with since before Catra got sick.

"What were you doing all the way here? Looking for Razz?"

Adora bites her lip. "Yeah, of course." She lies. Adora doesn't want to tell Catra that she is sulking, hiding her pain away from the people who love her.

The trek to Bright Moon is long and quiet. Adora has no idea what to say to this version of her wife. What she really wants is to hold her. To smell her scent and feel the warmth of her fur against her cheek. To be comforted like a child, for Catra to rub her hand across her back the way she used to do to Finn when they had a nightmare. But she doesn't even know where to begin to ask.

The guards stare at Catra like she's a ghost—it gives Adora some comfort that she's not a hallucination—but they otherwise stay quiet. They quickly make their way to the main hall where Glimmer normally holds court.

"Adora? Have you reconsidered already? I didn't think you'd—" Glimmer stops short, eyes wide as saucers as she looks at Catra. Her eyes then swing to Adora. "What the fuck did you do?"

She holds her hands up in surrender. "I didn't do anything, I swear! She was just *there* in the Whispering Woods."

"Why were you—? Never mind, let's go somewhere more private." Glimmer walks over to them, putting her hands on both of them and teleporting them into her study. "Bow!" She yells.

It takes him a minute, but he pokes his head in with a confused glance. "Glimmer, why are you—" He freezes as he catches sight of Catra. "Catra?" His eyes fill with tears as she looks at her.

"Yeah. So, I'm not supposed to be here." She lets out a nervous chuckle. "For obvious reasons. I was going into a portal and I wasn't trying to time travel. Ideas?"

Bow sits down in a chair, his knees looking shaky. "You're here." He mumbles to himself before looking at Adora. "Does Finn know?"

"No. I don't think we should tell them." Adora says quickly. "We're trying to get her back home. I'm not sure how they'll feel." SHe's not even sure how she feels, how could she justify bringing her child into this?

"Finn is a full-grown adult. They can make their own decisions." Glimmer is quick to point out. "If they want to see their mother again for the last time—" Her voice is choked and she glances at Catra. "—I'd do anything to see mine again. If I had that chance taken away from me, I'd be devasted."

"Can we stop talking about me like I'm not here?" Catra puts her hand on her hip, tail flicking in annoyance behind her. "I know you're all going through...things, grief, what have you. But I'm here and I think I should have a say in what happens to me."

"Sorry." Adora bites her lip, still staying a good distance from Catra. Her palms tingle with want. "What do you think?"

She sighs crossing her arms across her chest. "I think we need Entrapta. She was helping me with this portal, maybe she'll know what went wrong. And with Finn ..." Her eyes tighten as she thinks of them. "If they want to see me, I want to be there for them. I always want to be there for them." Her voice is a whisper by the end of it.

Adora nods her heart clenching in her chest. She'd expect nothing less from Catra. "Alright. I'll go get Finn and talk to them." A warm hand lands on her shoulder.

Glimmer gives her a sympathetic smile. "What if I go get Entrapta and Bow talks to Finn? Maybe you could have a moment alone or

you can spend time with Catra?"

The idea of letting Catra out of her sight feels impossible. "Catra, what do you want?"

"I'm fine to stay here with you if that makes the most sense." It's the diplomatic answer, one she's surely given because she doesn't want to step on any toes, but Adora can't find it in herself to fight it.

"Okay." Adora looks at Bow. "Be gentle with them when you break the news?" She feels a certain amount of guilt for having someone else tell Finn, but if she's honest, she's not sure she could manage to hold herself together and tell them all at once.

Bow gives her a warm smile. "Of course."

Bow and Glimmer clear out after that but not before both of them pull Catra in for a tight hug. Adora can feel the pain and jealousy eating holes into her as she watches Catra hug them back, reassuringly patting their arms.

The moment it's just them two, Adora feels nerves she doesn't understand. She knows Catra. Their love saved the universe, she'd spent her whole life at her side—until now. Why should she feel this way?

Catra eyes her with some hesitancy in her gaze. "You haven't touched me since I got here." There's no reproach in her voice, just an unspoken question.

"I'm not sure if I'm allowed to." She whispers. Adora feels raw. She's been emotionally spent for months now, first through Catra's sickness and now grieving her death. Even the idea still rolls her stomach with nausea weeks after the fact. "I want to, but I'm afraid."

Catra nods, her tail jerking to the side. "I think, if you died and I saw you—" She shakes her head, tears pooling in her eyes. "—I'd never let go."

Adora shakes her head, tugging on her hair. Catra's words make her palms itch, making her want to pull Catra tightly to her chest. She takes a slow breath through her nose.

"I can't do that. You have your whole life to get back to. Some young version of me that's going to rip apart the universe if she doesn't find you soon." She envies that Adora, the one who has a lifetime left to live. If she knew even half of what she knows now, she would have done so many things differently.

"You've always been a lot more selfless than I am." Catra gives her a small smile. "Good to see some things don't change."

A laugh leaves her lungs, Adora isn't sure how. "You always know the right thing to say." She sighs and bites her lip before she sobs out again. "Could I ... can I hold you?"

She rolls her eyes with a levity Adora can tell is feigned. "I'm your wife. Of course, you can hold me."

It takes Adora three steps to close the distance between them and then she has Catra in her arms and *fuck* what is Adora meant to do. Catra smells the same, the way she did before she was sick and she's warm and alive. Adora can't help but compare it to the last time she'd held Catra—she was dead and cold. Lighter somehow as if her personality and heart and soul gave her body some immovable heft that was now gone.

She feels Catra's ear twitch beside her cheek and that's when she realizes she's sobbing loudly, the same terrible reality-bending noises that she'd made the day Catra left her for good.

She tries to breathe through her nose but it's useless, clogged up as it is. She breathes through her mouth and tries to pull back. "I'm sorry—"

Catra pulls her close gripping Adora tightly. "No. You need this. Hold me." Adora does what Catra suggests, burying her head into her shoulder and letting herself cry until her tears are spent. She feels Catra's hand rub her back and her tail wrap around her

waist. "I'm so sorry, princess. I'm so sorry you have to go through this. I love you."

Adora takes a deep breath. "I love you too, Catra. Always. I'd never stop. No matter what." She closes her eyes tightly and they stand in silence, just two bodies intertwined.

When Adora opens her eyes again, she's a little shocked once again by how young Catra looks. "How old is Finn for you?"

Catra smiles softly. "They're four. A total menace."

Adora laughs brightly at that. "Oh God, I remember that." She shakes her head. "Have they stopped hiding in the laundry basket?"

She groans loudly. "No! And even though I know it's the first place I should check I always forget. They scare years off my life, I swear." Catra winces as her words catch up to her. "Sorry."

"It's okay. I'm not fragile." Catra narrows her eyes on Adora. "Okay, I'm a fucking wreck but that's not going to make me fall apart."

"Better." She pulls Adora in again for a tight hug. "I'm going to sound like a total asshole but I'm glad it's me."

"Huh?" She murmurs. Adora was distracted trying to memorize the way that Catra smelled again. "Glad you what?"

"Die first. I get the better deal."

Adora rolls her eyes. "You said that too when you realized. Trying to make me smile."

"Well, I hope I was more successful then."

Adora gives her a half-hearted grin. "Sorry. I can't imagine how awkward this feels for you."

She shakes her head, leaning it on Adora's shoulder. "Think about it. If you could comfort some other version of me, would you?"

Her shoulders relax. "Yeah." In any time or place, all she ever wanted was to be there for Catra. It's an easy choice.

"Then don't apologize to me. That's stupid." She says plainly, her tail wacking Adora's hip.

Adora clears her throat before pressing a soft kiss right between Catra's ears. "Right." She smiles, a big genuine smile for what feels like the first time in ages.

They startle when they hear a knock at the door. "Can I come in?" Adora immediately recognizes the voice, but she can tell that Catra doesn't.

"It's Finn." She supplies, watching as Catra's eyebrows jump to her hairline. She turns to the door, dropping her arms from around Catra. "Yeah. Come on in."

The door swings open but Finn takes a few tentative steps in. They cover their mouth when their eyes land on Catra. "Mama?"

She lets out a watery chuckle, her eyes darting all over them. "Yeah, that's me. God, you're so big." She wipes a tear in her eyes. "Come here, let me look at you."

Finn walks closer, their knees shaking the closer they get. "I never thought I'd see you again." They whisper what everyone has been thinking. "I don't know what to say."

Adora feels her eyes water again. She's so tired of crying but she doesn't know that she'll ever stop, especially when Finn's feelings are involved. She puts a hand on their shoulder squeezing it.

Catra shrugs. "Whatever you want, kid. Whatever you'd like for your mom to know." She gives Finn a tremulous smile. "I know it's not the same thing but maybe it'll help."

Before Adora can really process what's happening, Finn collapses in Catra's arms. They're shaking but they aren't crying, eyes shut tightly.

"I love you so much. I just—even if I was angry about something I always loved you." They whisper.

It looks just like when Finn was a kid, except their a whole head taller than Catra now. They lean against her shoulder, crouched down so she can run her fingers over their hair.

"Of course, baby. I know that. And I know your mama knew that too. That's not something we'd ever forget."

Adora reaches her hand out and rubs Finn's back. They pull up to their full height giving Catra a tremulous smile. "Thanks. That helped."

"Of course." She nods and then crosses her arms. "Did Glimmer go to look for Entrapta under a rock or something?"

"God, even back from the dead all you do is gripe." Glimmer shoots off, popping back into the room. Her eyes are warm when she looks at Catra. "Entrapta pointed out that she probably will be more help in her lab so I'm bringing everyone to her."

"Bleh, teleporting." Catra sticks out her tongue, her tail fluffing up like it always does when she thinks of magic like that. Over time, Catra got better at minimizing her reactions but she never overcame her uneasiness around it. The only magic she hardly minded was Adora's.

It takes Glimmer two trips to get everyone there. Catra grips Adora's arm like she always does when Glimmer has to teleport them. It made her heart clench—she'd almost forgotten, Glimmer hadn't teleported them together in so long. What else is Adora bound to forget?

Before she can spiral out on *that* thought, she looks up at Entrapta. She has streaks of gray in her hair that are familiar to

her, but Adora can tell they startle Catra.

She eyes Entrapta wearily for a moment. "Hey, Entrapta."

"Catra! I'm so excited it is this time!" Entrapta might have more wrinkles and she can't move quite as fast, but she makes up for it with enthusiasm. "I'm so excited to finally understand where the experiment went wrong. I love new data!" She lets one of her ponytails wrap around Catra briefly before focusing on her screen.

"What do you mean?" Adora is struck by how unsurprised Entrapta is. "Did you know Catra was coming here?"

"Of course, I did! I sent her the first time." She waves one of her ponytails as if that should've been obvious to Adora.

"I didn't know *when* Catra would come, but I know it was after she died so I've been monitoring to pick up any disturbances. What I found was *fascinating.*"

Catra's ears perk up at that. "You know why I ended up here? Why the portal failed?"

"It didn't fail so much as it was co-opted." Entrapta pulls up a diagram, spikes showing up suddenly toward the end of it. "The portal was functioning just fine—something dragged you here. A large beacon of magic, one of the strongest outbursts we've had in a long while."

Adora furrows her brow. Does that mean there's a threat out there? Something from Catra's time or their own that poses a danger to them?

"What could cause that?" Glimmer speaks everyone's question aloud.

Entrapta turns to look at them. "My best guess is Adora."

"Me? I didn't—I didn't do anything."

"Not intentionally." She looks back at her screen, her face bathed in the blue light generated by it. "As She-ra you're connected to not only the well of magic within you, but Etheria's magic. You know, since you restored it. What were you doing when you found Catra?"

Adora thinks back to the moment when she felt herself sinking into the ground, passively wishing she were dead. Thinking about how desperately she wanted to see Catra again.

"I—I was thinking about her. That I missed her." It's an understatement but Adora can't say more without frightening everyone.

"I think the magnitude of your grief interfered with the portal. In essence, Etheria recognized Catra and brought her to you, since she was already in a vulnerable place in time."

"It's my fault?" She whispers.

"Yes! Isn't that incredible? You must be devastated if you didn't even realize that you pulled her here." Entrapta stops what she's doing peeking out at Adora. "Sorry." She mutters before turning back to her keyboard. "I can send her back home, it's just going to take me some time to fix it. Also, I need Adora to let go of her."

Adora looks down at where their fingers are entangled—she hardly remembers doing it. For a brief wild second, she considers refusing and asking Catra to stay here. But she knows that's not how this goes—she can't leave a four-year-old Finn motherless and strip the joy of a lifetime away from herself. She reluctantly lets go of Catra's hand. "Is that enough?" She wonders if she'll get to touch her when they're saying goodbye. The thought of not being able to hold her one last time is already rotting her from the inside out.

"Oh no, not physically. You can touch Catra but your magic needs to let go. It's what's grounding her here."

She lets out a frustrated huff. "I'm not doing anything." She repeats.

Bow eyes the two of them. "I think maybe you and Catra need some space to figure it out." He puts his hand on Finn's shoulder. "How about you go to one of the other rooms while Entrapta figures out her end?"

She nods, tugging Catra with her until they go to the next room over. Adora isn't sure what to do. She doesn't feel like her magic is latched onto Catra—she doesn't feel much I'd anything right now if she's honest. It's an oasis when compared to the volatility of the last few weeks.

Catra looks at her soberly, hand still held tightly in her own. "How old was I?" Her voice breaks the silence and cracks.

Adora knows exactly what she's asking and her heart drops in her chest at the thought of answering. "Do you really want to know?"

"Not really but—you all don't look that old."

She sighs. Adora imagines if she were in that position, she might want to know how much time she had left too. "It's been forty-five years since the end of the war."

Catra's eyes widen, her grip on Adora stronger than before. "That's...that’s so little time."

"I know." There was still so much she wanted to do with Catra, so much more she wanted to have. It feels selfish, wanting more after already having so much, but Catra is the one who taught her it was okay to want.

"That's just another thirty-five for me." She shakes her head. "I'm about halfway done."

Adora feels a knot in her throat at the thought of this Catra dying too. "I'm sorry. Maybe I shouldn't have said anything." She hadn't thought at all when she saw Catra standing there, she just

reacted. Maybe her mistake was telling her she died in the first place.

"I'm glad to know." She gives a faint smile. "I mean you always know right? That someday it's all going to end. I've

outlived my life span many times over based on all the things I survived."

"I wasn't ready for you to go." Adora swallows thickly. "I'm still not."

"Remember the first time we did the older cadet training course?"

Adora's lips twitch into a smile. "You mean when I almost landed on my face if you hadn’t saved me?”

She thought she would pass it easily—Shadow Weaver had told her so. That she was special and if she worked hard, she’d likely get a record time to start. It didn’t work out that way. Adora was so bogged down by the expectations that she’d almost failed if Catra hadn’t been watching out for her.

“Yeah. You were so devastated about not being doing it perfectly.”

Catra had to find Adora hiding. It was one of the few times that their roles were reversed, Catra having to find a way to make herself soft and coax Adora to dinner. It had taken Catra allowing Adora to pet her ears and pretend she didn't notice Adora's cries before Adora allowed herself to face the world again.

Adora furrows her brow. “I don’t really see the connection.” She admits wearily.

Catra rolls her eyes but she has a fond smile on her lips. “Just because you aren’t ready to do something, doesn’t mean you can’t make it through.”

“I had you watching my back then.”

“You have plenty of people watching your back now.” Catra all but clutches her hand, searching her eyes. “And I have to believe that if there’s anything after Etheria … then I’m doing that. Keeping an eye on you.”

Adora smiles at that thought. “I hope you are doing something more entertaining than that.”

“Who knows? Maybe I orchestrated this whole thing from wherever I am, just so I can yell at you some more.” She teases softly.

“You haven’t yelled at me.”

“Yet.” Catra’s grin shrinks, and she gets a faraway look in her eye.

"You look bothered. About something else, I mean." Even knowing Catra's upset, it's so rewarding to stand next to her and check in on her. "What is it?"

She doesn’t even pretend to be fine. "Do I tell her? My Adora?” She sighs. “Would you want to know if it was you? Well, you know what I mean."

Immediately, Adora shakes her head picking up on Catra's question. "It's a lot to hear but—don't. Not if you can help it." Adora tries to think about what she would do at that time when Finn was underfoot and life with Catra was near perfect. If she knew exactly when it would all come crashing down. "I'll try to change it. I'd do anything to change it but I know that would mean not enjoying it."

She can't trade the years she had for some future where maybe she changed things but she wasn't there for her family in the present. And she knows herself well enough to know that she might fall into temptation.

"That does sound like you." She admits.

"Can you blame me?"

"Not really." Catra shakes her head and sighs. "It's a lot to keep from her."

Adora shrugs. She knows what she knows now, but it's not like she can impart that to Catra. Some things you have to learn through time. "It's between you and her if you want to tell her."

"I don't want to hurt her." She sighs, running a hand through her hair. "It was... it was good?"

"I wouldn't trade a minute of it," Adora answers honestly. "I can't say it was the same for her—but I like to think that she wouldn't either." Catra had said as much on her deathbed, but Adora wasn't sure if she believed her. She wants to so badly, but there's no way to know if she was just comforting Adora.

Catra scoffs. "I know she wouldn't."

"You can't know that."

"I can! I am her in a lot of ways."

"But you don't know everything that happens. Whether she had regrets."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Of course, she has regrets. All people have regrets, Adora." Something flickers across her face. "Me more than most." She reaches out, her clawed hand grasping Adora's arm. "But all I've ever wanted was to live my life out with you. If I got to do that, if we got to be family—then it was worth it."

Adora bites her lip, nodding slightly. "Thank you." She takes a deep breath and feels something drop loose in her chest. "Let me try something."

She opens her arms and pulls Catra tight into her chest. She feels her laugh under the pressure. “Need me to do anything but be a teddy bear?” She wraps her tail around Adora’s waist.

“No. You’re doing great.” She feels herself smile. Adora shuts her eyes and focuses on the warmness inside her. She can visualize her magic—She-ra’s magic, a golden amorphous light bright in her chest. She tries to feel beyond that and there is something there she can’t place. It feels like a twine wrapped around the light, almost binding it down. “Catra … do you feel a … tether?”

“Between us?”

“Yeah. Maybe in your chest?”

Catra is silent for a moment, her ears pricking up. “I don’t feel anything different.” She says slowly after taking stock of herself.

“Okay.” Adora thinks of the magic inside her. She imagines it expanding in her chest, burning bright like it does when she calls on She-ra. She pushes until the twine snaps her magic pushing it to the point of no return.

“Oh! I felt that.”

Adora looks down at Catra, although now from a greater height. “The snap?”

“I can feel the loss of whatever that was,” Catra confirms, before looking up at Adora. “You … do you always look like that when you’re She-ra?”

Adora looks down at herself—nothing feels out of place. She hadn’t transformed in months—with Catra as her focus and without a need for She-ra, there simply wasn’t cause to. “Yeah, what do you see?”

“You look *young*.” Her voice is filled with wonder and Adora realizes what it is Catra sees.

“Oh! Yeah. She-ra doesn’t really age. I guess your Adora is too young for her to have realized that.” Adora doesn’t think she noticed the difference until she started to go gray in her forties.

“Alright.” Catra eyes her as she transforms back. “So … let’s find the others then. See if I can go back home?”

Adora nods. “Yeah.” She reaches her hand out to Catra. “Would you mind if we took the long way back?”

“Not at all.”

After Entrapta confirmed that she’d be able to send Catra back now, no one rushes to suggest she leave. Everyone basks in the attention and Finn practically spoils in it, not leaving their mother’s side the whole time. Adora is never too far either, drinking in Catra’s presence the way a nocturnal creature might regard the day moon. Every time she looks at Catra, she feels even brighter than before, and Adora worries about how she’ll adjust to when she’s gone for good. Again.

It's Bow who clears his throat authoritatively, looking at everyone. “I think it’s time that we let Catra go back to her home now.” The room goes silent, and everyone looks at each other. Both Catra and Finn’s ears are pinned back as they share a look. "I think we need to say our goodbyes."

Finn all but latches onto Catra, pulling her into a fierce hug. It’s odd to look at them—although they are around the same age, Finn clings the way they haven’t in years. “I love you.”

“I love you too, Finnie.”

Bow and Glimmer pull Catra into a hug the moment that Finn lets go, murmuring to each other. They shoot Adora a supposedly covert look so she can imagine what it’s about.

Adora turns to Entrapta, letting them have their moment together. “It’ll be safe for her?”

Entrapta nods quickly, turning to one of her screens. “Very safe. I’ve never done a time portal before but I’ve been preparing for years for this. Besides, we know I send her back because Catra

closes the loop. She'll be back in her own time and will live out the rest of her life."

Adora swallows the lump in her throat. It's what she wants for Catra desperately. "Good."

She almost bumps into Catra when she turns around. She takes a deep breath. She wants to be brave, but she worries that the moment Catra is gone she'll be right back where she started.

Catra wraps her tail around her, leaning her forehead against Adora's. "I believe in you. I know that you can find meaning and purpose and joy." She places a soft kiss on Adora's cheek.

"I don't know that I can."

Catra smiles at her, before hugging her tightly. "I believe enough for both of us. Know that I'm rooting for you."

The idea of a Catra somewhere in another time and place thinking of her, wishing her well—it does something to lighten the grief in her chest. It makes her think of *her* Catra, the one she got to spend her life with. She knows what Catra wants for her, knows that she is fiercely loved. Loved in a way most people can only hope to find someday.

"Please be safe. Tell your Adora that she needs to love you well."

"She already does that."

She bites her lip. "A reminder can't hurt." Adora would rattle her younger self if she could, impress upon her how important time is. How she isn't going to get it back again.

Catra shakes her head. "She doesn't need a reminder." She pokes Adora's forehead. "*You* need a reminder to keep your shit together."

Adora laughs, a free one that rattles out without her permission. "I'll try to remember as best I can." Catra still stares at her, a

trying look that means she doesn’t believe Adora. She places a soft kiss on Catra’s palm and then lets her hand go before taking a step back. “I promise.”

Catra nods softly before turning to Entrapta. “Ready?”

“Of course! This is so exciting.” Her smile fades for a minute as she looks at Catra. “I’ll miss things like this.”

“Thanks. I’m sure we still have plenty to get up to when I am.”

“Right! Remember you have to give me this!” Entrapta pulls up a fresh parchment, her scrawl filling both sides. “This will give me enough, so I’ll be ready to send the next you back.” She turns back to the screen, her hands and hair frantically pressing buttons. “Everyone, stand back!”

Before Adora gets a chance to react, a portal opens up in the room, reflexive like a mirror. Catra walks right up to it, slowly but without hesitation. It reminds Adora of the many times she’s watched Catra walk away from her—some innocuous, like watching Catra walk toward the bathroom to wash up for the night, others heart-wrenching, like the night she left Adora before she delivered the failsafe. None felt like this.

Catra looks back for a moment, shooting Adora one last smile before she walks through. Just like that, she’s gone. Adora keeps staring, even after the portal collapses quietly.

She feels a hand come down on her shoulder. "You're going to be okay, mom?"

Finn's smile is tremulous, clearly shaken by Catra's brief presence the same way Adora is. Adora wraps them in a hug, squeezing them tightly.

"I don't know. But I'm going to try."

As lonely as the world feels without Catra, she knows she can't give up. Adora is used to carrying burdens on her shoulder—used

to sharing them with Catra. Now it's just her but it's not only the grief she has to carry—she has to find a way to carry the joy that was meant for both of them.

"Alright. I'm here if you need me. Or if you want to see the kids." They add with a soft smile.

"I know. You're a good person, Finn."

Finn shakes their head. "I'm just *your* kid. And I want you to be okay."

Adora nods slowly. "I'm—I'll stay with your aunt Glimmer for a few weeks. Just to clear my head." She's nowhere near ready to give up the home she built with Catra but she knows if she goes back now after just seeing her again, she won't get better. And she promised Catra she'd try. "I'll come back home after the anniversary."

She knows the next few weeks are going to be awful—grappling with Catra's death, meeting and losing this younger version of her wife, and then having to deal with the celebrations that, for Adora, not only commemorate the end of the war but also their first kiss.

“When your mother died in my arms—it was like losing all myself. But seeing her again reminded me of something.” She puts her hands on Finn’s shoulders. “There are pieces of me here. In you, in my friends, in your children. And there are pieces of Catra too. I just have to hold onto that.”

Finn nods, one of their hands coming to rest on Adora’s atop their shoulder. “We all love you. I don’t want to lose you just because we lost mama—I’ve been scared.”

“I’m here.” Adora bites her lip. She has no doubt that she’ll be lost in her grief again. Adora can already feel it waiting in the wings for her, like a familiar friend. She just can’t let herself drown in it. “I’m here, and I’m not going anywhere.”

End Notes

A lot of this is inspired by my grandfather. He lost my grandmother recently-ish after over fifty years of marriage. They had a beautiful love story and even in death, I realize it's never really over. If you made it this far, I'd love to know your thoughts.

Kudos and comments help (especially when I'm in a funk like lately). You can find me on Twitter, Bluesky, and Tumblr.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!